hamstrung by its alliances. Many of them also argued that, in Punjab, its alliance with the Akali Dal had 'antagonised' Hindu voters. In Bengal, they felt the anti-communist vote ended up going to the Congress since it was felt that the Jan Sangh would not be able to defeat the communists, while in UP, it was felt that casteism cost the party dearly, since Jat–Ahir votes were going to Charan Singh's Bharatiya Kranti Dal (BKD).[112]

Mehta argued that none of these tactical reasons held up to deeper scrutiny. If the Congress was focusing on wresting back seats the Jan Sangh had won, it was doing that just as strongly with the communists. The Communist Party was capable of 'maintaining these seats in spite of severe Congress opposition in these constituencies while Jana Sangh succumbs in such circumstances'. If it was a question of stature, then no new entrants could ever hope to make it in politics against the Congress. Besides, the Communist Party's young guns were managing to win elections, but not the Jan Sangh's. For example, while 'Sri Ram Prakash Gupta, the young Jana Sangh leader failed to defeat Congress in UP, the young and dynamic Jyoti Basu was able to shatter the Congress and bring Communist Party Marxist into power in Bengal'.

If the wave of anti-Congressism had subsided, then, between 1967 and 1969, the Congress would not have gone from 127 seats to fifty-five in West Bengal, from 128 to 118 in Bihar and from forty-seven to thirty-eight in Punjab, Mehta argued. Such excuses, he felt, were 'a big lie': 'This is only trying to fool one's own self as well as the ordinary Jana Sangh workers.' In Punjab, for example, though the Jan Sangh's state president and finance minister, Dr Baldev Prakash, was defeated from Amritsar, the Communist Party's Satyapal Dang won the same seat, despite being in alliance with the Akali Dal. Similarly, in UP, Sangh candidates were defeated in urban areas like Lucknow and Bareilly, where there was no significant caste-based voting by Jats or Ahirs.[113]

Lessons the Sangh Learnt from the Communists on Winning Elections